

Mannheim Business School

Assignment

Market and Morals - Buying Wedding Toast

Master in Sustainability and Impact Management

Module - Impact Investing

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Declaration of Authorship

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Michael Spilger

Mannheim, December 5, 2024

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1 Task

Some websites offer ghostwritten wedding speeches. After answering a questionnaire and paying \$149, you will receive a custom toast that is professionally written within three business days. Other websites sell pre-written wedding speeches for \$19.95, which come with a money-back guarantee.

Suppose, on your wedding day, your best man/maid of honor delivers a heartwarming toast, a speech so moving it brings tears to your eyes. You later learn that it was bought online.

1. Would you care?
2. Would the toast mean less than it did at first, before you knew it was written by a paid professional?
3. Finally, do you think that some market mechanisms change the value or meaning of the goods and social practices?

2 Answer

2.1 Would you care?

Yes, I would care upon learning that the speech was purchased online. The initial emotional impact of the toast was profound because I believed it was a genuine expression of my best man's or maid of honor's feelings. Discovering that it was crafted by a professional raises questions about the authenticity of the sentiments expressed. It makes me wonder whether the words were truly reflective of our relationship or simply a generic message designed to elicit an emotional response.

While it's understandable that not everyone is comfortable with public speaking or eloquent in expressing their feelings, the value of a wedding toast lies in its sincerity, not its perfection. If my friend had difficulty articulating their thoughts and sought assistance to better convey their genuine feelings, that might be different. However, purchasing a pre-written speech or outsourcing the task entirely suggests a lack of personal investment in the gesture, which diminishes its significance.

2.2 Would the toast mean less than it did at first, before you knew it was written by a paid professional?

Yes, the toast would mean less to me after learning it was written by a paid professional. Initially, I believed the heartfelt words were a direct reflection of our shared experiences and the bond we have. Knowing that the speech was bought undermines that perception. It shifts the moment from being a personal and intimate exchange to a transactional one, reducing the authenticity of the gesture.

The essence of such a speech isn't about flawless delivery or poetic language; it's about the personal touch and genuine emotions behind it. If the speech was merely polished by someone else but based on my friend's own thoughts and feelings, it might still hold significant meaning. However, a pre-written or generically crafted speech lacks the personal connection that makes such moments special.

2.3 Finally, do you think that some market mechanisms change the value or meaning of the goods and social practices?

I believe market mechanisms have a profound impact on the value and meaning of goods and social practices, especially in areas like healthcare, relationships, and family life. When markets enter spaces traditionally guided by personal values and moral considerations, they can crowd out intrinsic motivations, reshaping how we perceive some of the most vital aspects of our lives.

In healthcare, for instance, commodification can shift priorities in troubling ways. When profit drives decisions, patient care risks becoming secondary. Life-saving medications might be priced so high that they remain out of reach for many, turning healthcare—a basic human right—into a privilege for the wealthy. This not only undermines our moral duty to care for the sick but also erodes trust between patients and providers. Financial considerations begin to overshadow well-being, changing how we view health and its accessibility.

The effects are just as unsettling in relationships. When market principles seep into personal connections, the authenticity of human bonds can suffer. Think of dating apps offering premium features or matchmaking services that promise love for a price. These approaches often reduce relationships to transactions, prompting people to evaluate partners based on superficial traits or economic benefits instead of emotional connection or compatibility. The profound act of building a relationship grounded in respect and understanding can be overshadowed by this marketplace mindset.

Family dynamics also feel the weight of these changes. Outsourcing traditionally intimate roles, such as caregiving or tutoring, to paid services can unintentionally weaken familial bonds. While practical in some cases, excessive reliance on these services might distance family members from one another. Similarly, paying children for chores or achievements may encourage certain behaviors, but it risks shifting their motivations. Instead of contributing out of love or responsibility, children may start to expect rewards for basic tasks, undermining the mutual support and shared values that families are built upon.

The broader implications of this encroachment are significant. Economists and ethicists often refer to the “crowding out” effect, where external incentives like money replace internal motivations like altruism or love. When financial gain drives actions that should stem from duty or care, the social fabric begins to unravel. Trust and cooperation falter as individualism takes precedence, and people become less inclined to act for the collective good.

Markets also reshape societal norms. If everything is for sale, we may start to believe that value is only measurable in monetary terms, neglecting ethics, emotional fulfillment, or social responsibility. This perspective risks reducing our world to one where everything is a transaction, leaving little room for the deeper meanings that give life richness and purpose.

Ultimately, while markets are exceptional tools for allocating resources and driving innovation, they are not suited to govern every aspect of life. In areas like healthcare, relationships, and family life, introducing market dynamics can erode the moral foundations and human connections that define us. It's vital to recognize where markets belong and where they don't, ensuring that spaces for love, trust, and moral considerations remain untouched by economic transactions.